UNDER-REVIEW

Move Preparedness Supplies Safely

Plan before moving water containers, go-bags, sandbags, animal supplies, batteries, and other preparedness equipment. A lighter trip is usually the safer trip.

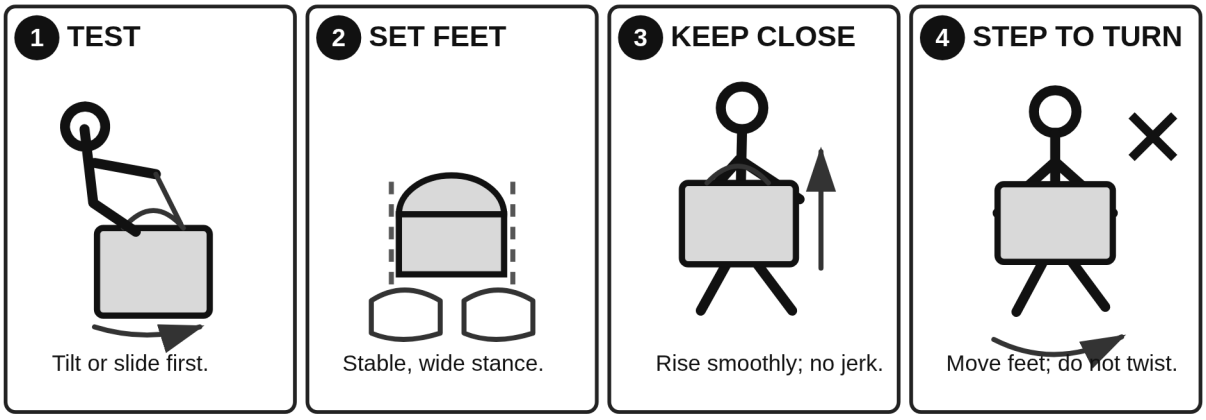
✕ DANGER — STOP NOW

STOP—do not lift or continue if the load shifts or is unstable; the route is wet, slippery, dark, steep, or obstructed; your grip is poor; or you feel pain, dizziness, shortness of breath, unusual weakness, or fatigue. Stop if the weight is beyond your capability. Set it down safely if you can—never try to “push through.”

BEFORE YOU LIFT

1. **Test without committing:** read a weight label if present, then push, tilt, or lift one edge a few centimeters. If it is hard to control, do not lift it.
2. **Make it smaller or lighter:** remove items; use smaller water containers; half-fill when appropriate; or divide food, animal feed, litter, and sandbags into more trips. Close lids and secure loose contents.
3. **Clear the whole route:** choose the shortest usable path. Remove cords, rugs, debris, and low obstacles. Open doors, turn on lights, secure pets, and identify a level set-down spot before starting.
4. **Choose an aid:** use a cart, hand truck, wagon, rolling bag, shoulder-height shelf, ramp, or other rated equipment when available. Keep loads low and secured; stay within the aid's rating. Do not ride on material-handling equipment.

LIFT AND CARRY



Test → set → hold close → step. The safest posture cannot make an over-heavy or unstable load safe.

Original Fire Watch diagram; technical basis: OSHA and NIOSH.

SKL-008

Move Preparedness Supplies Safely — continued

1. Wear secure, closed-toe footwear. Stand on firm, dry, stable footing with feet apart and one foot slightly forward. Get close to the load.
2. Use secure handles or opposite lower corners. Keep a neutral, comfortable back position; bend at the hips and knees as your abilities allow. Keep fingers away from pinch points.
3. Brace gently and rise smoothly with the load close to your body. Do not jerk. Keep the load between knee and shoulder height when practical, and keep your view clear.
4. **Never twist while holding the load.** Turn your whole body by taking small steps. Set down smoothly on a stable surface; protect fingers and toes.

UNDER-REVIEW

Move Preparedness Supplies Safely — continued

No universal “safe weight” applies to everyone. Size, shape, distance from the body, repetition, terrain, health, and individual capability all matter. When unsure, divide the load, use an aid, or ask for help.

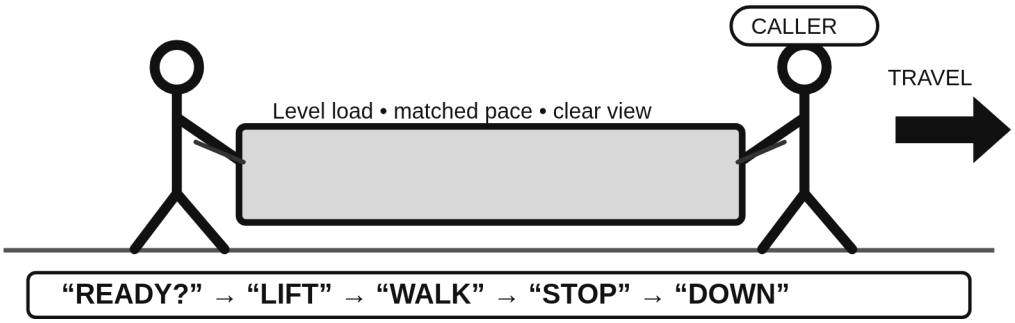
UNDER-REVIEW

Move Preparedness Supplies Safely — continued

Plan shared carries and accessible alternatives before an evacuation, outage, or storm makes the job urgent.

TWO-PERSON CARRY

1. Do not use a team carry for a load that is unstable, leaking, hard to grip, or beyond the pair's combined control. Divide it or use a rated aid instead.
2. Agree on the destination, route, set-down point, and commands. The person with the clearest view is the **caller**. Match grip and carrying height.
3. The caller asks, “Ready?” Both confirm. On “Lift,” rise together. Walk with short, matched steps; do not twist. Either person may call “Stop.”
4. On “Down,” both lower together. If a grip slips, the load shifts, the route changes, or either person has pain or fatigue, call “Stop” immediately—do not try to save a falling load.



One caller; either person can stop. Keep the load level and move only on agreed commands.
Original Fire Watch diagram; technical basis: OSHA and NIOSH.

SKL-008

ALTERNATIVES AND HELP ARRANGED IN ADVANCE

- ☐ Store frequently used supplies within easy reach and near where they will be used. Avoid floor-level and overhead storage when possible.
- ☐ Choose smaller containers, rolling go-bags, carts with brakes, long-handled tools, delivery, or staged caches. Transfer supplies while seated only if the seat is stable and the motion is comfortable.
- ☐ Do not hang heavy bags on a wheelchair, walker, or mobility device unless its manufacturer permits it; added weight can affect stability and braking. Keep mobility-device paths wide and clear.
- ☐ Ask a household member, neighbor, caregiver, animal-assistance contact, or community group now. Practice once in ordinary conditions and confirm who brings the cart, who handles animals, and who is the backup.

Move Preparedness Supplies Safely — continued

◎ LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL

My help plan

Supplies I will not move alone: _____
Primary helper / method: _____ Backup: _____
Aid and storage location: _____ Route checked on: _____
How I will request help: _____ Plan practiced on: _____

UNDER-REVIEW

Move Preparedness Supplies Safely — continued

SUPPLIES ARE NOT INJURED PEOPLE

✕ DANGER — STOP NOW

These lifting steps are for supplies—not for moving an injured person. Moving someone can worsen spine or other injuries. Call emergency services, follow dispatcher instructions, and do not move the person unless there is an immediate danger (such as fire, smoke, traffic, or collapse) or the dispatcher directs you to move them.

Comparable technical review completed: The instructions and stop conditions in this under-review draft were checked point by point against OSHA and NIOSH manual-material-handling guidance; the injured-person distinction was checked against Red Cross first-aid guidance. This documented source-comparison review is not a claim of clinician authorship. Before changing the status to approved, record the repository's separately required independent human review by an occupational-safety professional, physical therapist, occupational therapist, ergonomist, or similarly qualified clinician.

SOURCES

Occupational Safety and Health Administration, “Materials Handling—Lifting.” National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health, *Ergonomic Guidelines for Manual Material Handling*, DHHS (NIOSH) Publication No. 2007-131 (2007). American Red Cross, “First Aid Steps.” Accessed 2026-09-29.

SKL-008